

million workers? From the macro perspective, it seems like a rounding error. It's a classic case of context-free data.

During the GFC, there were massive firings. Shotgun weddings led to redundancies and entire departments were cut. My daily email notes were generating a bounce rate (dead emails) of 20% or worse every month (and I removed bad addresses weekly). Unemployment spiked to 10%; layoffs were ubiquitous. It was a very ugly period, especially so close to the dotcom debacle a few years earlier. Even that implosion sent unemployment to 6.3%, almost double current levels.

You can see the psychological damage created by the financial crisis. People had a form of economic-PTSD. The 2023–25 era—even with higher interest rates and slowing growth—was not remotely comparable to those earlier eras.

The Death Tax

Denominator blindness is so prevalent, it even sneaks into our language.

A perfect example is the Federal Estate Tax, which as of 2024 levied a 40% tax on any estate over \$13.61 million for a single individual, or \$27.22 million for a married couple.

In the 1940s, attempts to rename estate taxes the “Death Tax” met with only limited success. Frank Luntz, the Republican communication wizard, was more successful in the 1990s, and drove widespread adoption of the phrase.^{[132](#)}

The most recent data is the calendar year 2023, when about three million Americans died, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.^{[133](#)} Only 5,000 of these people left an estate that owed any federal taxes. Said differently, 2,995,000 Americans died in 2023 without owing a penny in estate taxes.

Why name something for the 0.167% outcome? When 99.82% of deaths